

EXB-02 · EXAM BLUEPRINT

Domain weightings and the 40/40/20 rule

Why the PCL-AI examination is weighted the way it is, and exactly what a group weight does to a score

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PROJECT CONTROLS INSTITUTE GLOBAL, INC.
AI proposes. The professional disposes.

— Summary

The PCL-AI examination weights three groups at 40 per cent for project accounting and finance, 40 per cent for project management principles and 20 per cent for AI knowledge and practical approach. This document defends that weighting as a measurement decision rather than a preference, shows the arithmetic of how a group weight converts into a score contribution, works out what a weak group actually costs a candidate, and states plainly what the weighting does not do — including the fact that it sets no per-domain and no per-group hurdle. It applies to the PCL-AI only; no examination blueprint exists yet for PFL-AI or PML-AI.

— About this document

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Domain weightings and the 40/40/20 rule

In one paragraph. The PCL-AI examination weights three groups at 40 per cent for project accounting and finance, 40 per cent for project management principles and 20 per cent for AI knowledge and practical approach. This document defends that weighting as a measurement decision rather than a preference, shows the arithmetic of how a group weight converts into a score contribution, works out what a weak group actually costs a candidate, and states plainly what the weighting does not do — including the fact that it sets no per-domain and no per-group hurdle. It applies to the PCL-AI only; no examination blueprint exists yet for PFL-AI or PML-AI.

Who this is for. Candidates planning revision time; training providers allocating course hours; assessment professionals auditing whether the weighting is defensible; and employers asking what proportion of a PCL-AI holder's assessment was actually about their own discipline.

— 1. A weighting is a claim, not a preference

Every weighted examination makes a public assertion: this is how much of the competence we are certifying sits in that part of the discipline. It is the most consequential single number in an examination specification, because it determines what a candidate studies, what a training provider teaches, and what a pass actually attests.

Most certification bodies publish a weighting and stop. The number arrives without a defence, and a reader cannot tell whether it came from a job-task analysis, a committee vote, or the relative enthusiasm of whoever wrote the syllabus. The Institute's position is that an undefended weighting is an unaudited claim, so this document does three things: it states the arithmetic consequences precisely, it gives the grounds for the decision, and it names the point at which the decision will be tested against evidence rather than argument.

The weighting itself is set out in [EXB-01 – Examination blueprint – PCL-AI §4](#), which is the authoritative statement. This document explains and defends it.

— 2. The weighting, and what is unusual about it

Group	Domains	Knowledge areas	Share of knowledge areas	Weight
Project accounting & finance	D1–D4	19	31.1 %	40 %
Project management principles	D5–D12	35	57.4 %	40 %
AI knowledge & practical approach	D13	7	11.5 %	20 %
Total	13	61	100 %	100 %

Shares of knowledge areas are $19 \div 61$, $35 \div 61$ and $7 \div 61$, rounded to one decimal place.

The weighting is deliberately **not** proportional to the size of the content. Thirty-five knowledge areas of project management principles carry the same weight as nineteen knowledge areas of accounting and finance, and seven knowledge areas of AI carry half as much as either. That disproportion is the whole point, and it is defensible only if it corresponds to something real about the work.

— 3. What a group weight does to a score

Illustrative figures throughout this section. Percentages are of the scored content within each group; the overall figure is a percentage of the total scored content. All results are rounded to one decimal place.

The weighting is realised **through the composition of the form, not through per-item score weights**. Every scored item counts the same. A form is assembled so that 40 per cent of its scored items come from Group 1, 40 per cent from Group 2 and 20 per cent from Group 3, and the score is then simply the proportion answered correctly. Those two descriptions are arithmetically identical — if the group item counts are $0.40N$, $0.40N$ and $0.20N$, then $(0.40N \cdot p_1 + 0.40N \cdot p_2 + 0.20N \cdot p_3) \div N = 0.40p_1 + 0.40p_2 + 0.20p_3$ — so the weighted formula below is the correct way to reason about a score, and no item is secretly worth more than another.

Overall % = (0.40 × Group 1 %) + (0.40 × Group 2 %) + (0.20 × Group 3 %)

3.1 Two candidates, one score

	Group 1 (40 %)	Group 2 (40 %)	Group 3 (20 %)	Overall
Candidate A — within-group score	80.0 %	70.0 %	40.0 %	
Candidate A — contribution	$0.40 \times 80.0 = 32.0$	$0.40 \times 70.0 = 28.0$	$0.20 \times 40.0 = 8.0$	68.0 %
Candidate B — within-group score	90.0 %	70.0 %	20.0 %	
Candidate B — contribution	$0.40 \times 90.0 = 36.0$	$0.40 \times 70.0 = 28.0$	$0.20 \times 20.0 = 4.0$	68.0 %

Both candidates score 68.0 per cent overall and both clear 65 per cent. Throughout this document, 65 per cent is used as the reference because it is the platform's **configured** pass mark; the definitive standard will be set by a modified-Angoff standard-setting study, and the arithmetic below works the same way against whatever standard that study sets. See [EXB-05 – Standard setting: modified Angoff and the pass mark](#).

The two candidates are not equivalent professionals. Candidate B is a stronger accountant and, on this evidence, has close to no governed-AI judgement at all — and the weighted total conceals that, which is exactly why the result carries a domain-level breakdown and why §6 discusses hurdles honestly rather than pretending the issue away.

3.2 What a weak group costs

A group you abandon does not cost you its weight; it costs you the whole of its weight, and raises the bar on everything else.

Score **zero** in the AI group and the maximum overall score available is $40 + 40 = \mathbf{80.0 \text{ per cent}}$. To reach 65 per cent from there, the average across the other two groups must be:

$$65 \div 0.80 = 81.25 \%$$

$$\text{Check: } (0.40 \times 81.25) + (0.40 \times 81.25) + (0.20 \times 0) = 32.5 + 32.5 + 0 = 65.0 \%$$

So a candidate who writes off Domain 13 has quietly agreed to score above 81 per cent across the other twelve domains — nineteen knowledge areas of accounting and thirty-five of project management principles — to pass. Very few candidates who plan to skip the AI content have done that arithmetic before they sit.

3.3 The marginal value of a point

Improving your within-group score by 20 percentage points is worth:

- **8.0 points overall** in either 40 per cent group ($0.40 \times 20 = 8.0$);
- **4.0 points overall** in the 20 per cent group ($0.20 \times 20 = 4.0$).

That is the correct way to prioritise revision when time is short: the weight tells you what a point of improvement is worth, and your own diagnostic tells you where a point is cheapest to buy. The two together, not either alone, give the plan.

3.4 The number nobody computes: implied weight per knowledge area

If coverage within a group were spread evenly across its knowledge areas — which the blueprint does not promise, and which §5 qualifies — the implied weight of a single knowledge area would be:

Group	Weight ÷ knowledge areas	Implied weight per knowledge area
Project accounting & finance	$40 \div 19$	2.11 %
Project management principles	$40 \div 35$	1.14 %
AI knowledge & practical approach	$20 \div 7$	2.86 %

Read the last column again. **A knowledge area in the AI group carries exactly two and a half times the implied weight of a knowledge area in project management principles** — $(20 \div 7) \div (40 \div 35) = 2.5$ — and about 1.36 times that of an accounting and finance knowledge area — $(20 \div 7) \div (40 \div 19) = 1.357$.

This is the single most useful figure in the document for a candidate deciding where the next study hour goes, and it inverts the intuition almost everyone starts with. Domain 13 looks like one domain out of thirteen. Per knowledge area, it is the densest content on the paper.

4. Why these three weights

4.1 Why 40 per cent for project accounting and finance

Because the failure mode this credential exists to prevent is a cost report that does not reconcile to the accounts, and the people who produce those reports are, as a population, weakest here.

A controls professional works at the boundary between the project's own measurement of itself and the entity's statutory position. Cost incurred, revenue recognised, work executed, amounts certified and amounts invoiced are five different numbers on the same contract in the same month.

A professional who cannot say why they differ, and which of them belongs in which report, cannot be relied on to report a project honestly — and will, under pressure, report whichever number is most comfortable.

The Institute's judgement is that this is the largest genuine competence gap in the practising population, and weighting is the only instrument an examination has for saying so. **PCI interpretation**, and stated as such.

4.2 Why 40 per cent for project management principles

Because it is the discipline itself, and because a wide surface examined thinly is still the surface a controls professional stands on.

This is the largest group by content — thirty-five knowledge areas covering cost control, earned value, commercial and contract management, the delivery lifecycle, adaptive delivery, scheduling, the business process cycles and risk. Weighted equally with a group half its size, each of its knowledge areas is sampled less densely. That is a real trade-off and it has a real cost: a candidate can be examined on proportionately less of what they do every day.

It is accepted deliberately. This is the content practitioners are most likely to have learned on the job, and an examination adds least where experience already teaches most. The value of the assessment is concentrated where practice does not reliably produce competence — which is §4.1 and §4.3.

4.3 Why 20 per cent for AI, and why that is not a gesture

Because a fifth of the paper is the smallest weight that cannot be revised away, and because the alternative positions are both worse.

A credential that weighted AI at five per cent would be making a claim about the discipline that the Institute does not believe: that governed use of these tools is a peripheral skill a professional can acquire later. A credential that weighted it at forty per cent would be certifying something other than project controls.

Twenty per cent has a specific property. It is large enough that a candidate cannot pass while ignoring the group — §3.2 shows what ignoring it actually requires — and small enough that the credential remains a project controls credential rather than a technology credential. Combined with the density figure in §3.4, it means Domain 13 must be studied properly rather than skimmed the week before.

The content is vendor-neutral and concerns technique, data, governance and accountability rather than products. That is what makes a 20 per cent weight defensible over a three-year certification cycle: tools change inside a cycle, and what the group examines does not.

4.4 AI is also examined outside its group

The 20 per cent is the group weight for Domain 13. It is not the total AI exposure on a form. Every domain in the body of knowledge carries embedded coverage of AI as it applies to that domain, and an item in Group 1 or Group 2 may put a machine-generated output in front of a candidate and ask what a competent professional does with it. Such items are scored to the domain of their subject matter, not to Domain 13 — see [EXB-01](#) §6. A candidate estimating their AI exposure from the group weight alone is estimating low.

— 5. What the weighting does not do

It sets no per-domain weight. Weights attach to the three groups. The Institute publishes no percentage for any individual domain and will not confirm one informally. If coverage within a group were spread evenly across its member domains, Group 1 would imply about 10 per cent per domain ($40 \div 4$), Group 2 about 5 per cent ($40 \div 8$) and Group 3 the full 20 per cent — but the blueprint does not promise even spread, and those figures are an illustration of the structure, not a published specification. Treat them as a sanity check on your revision plan and nothing more.

It sets no per-domain hurdle. The domain breakdown on a result is diagnostic. There is no requirement to reach a threshold in each domain separately.

It does not fix how many items each group contains. The weighting is a proportion, and a proportion of an unknown total is still unknown in absolute terms. The number of scored items in each group will follow from the total, which **will be confirmed by a formal job-task analysis** — **[CONFIRM: number of scored items per group, once the job-task analysis fixes the total]**. See [EXB-06 – Job-task analysis: where the blueprint gets its authority](#).

It is not itself the passing standard. A weighting decides what the score is made of. The standard decides how much of it is enough. Those are separate decisions taken by separate methods; the second is in [EXB-05 – Standard setting: modified Angoff and the pass mark](#).

— 6. The honest limitation: a compensatory model has a floor problem

This is the objection a competent assessment reviewer raises first, and it deserves the arithmetic rather than a deflection.

The model is **compensatory**: strength in one group offsets weakness in another. Follow that to its boundary. A candidate scoring 100 per cent in project accounting and finance and 100 per cent in the AI group has already banked $40 + 20 = 60$ points. They need five more, and five points from a 40 per cent group requires:

$$5 \div 0.40 = 12.5 \%$$

$$\text{Check: } (0.40 \times 100) + (0.40 \times 12.5) + (0.20 \times 100) = 40.0 + 5.0 + 20.0 = 65.0 \%$$

So on the arithmetic alone, a candidate could score 12.5 per cent across the whole of project management principles — cost control, earned value, contracts, lifecycle, scheduling, process cycles and risk — and still pass. By symmetry the same is true of the accounting and finance group.

Two things should be said about that, and the Institute declines to say only the comforting one.

The scenario is close to unreachable in practice. Two perfect group scores are extraordinarily rare, and the domain-crossing design of the items means a candidate who genuinely cannot read a schedule or an earned value position will lose marks inside the other groups as well, because the scenarios there assume that competence. The arithmetic boundary and the empirical boundary are not the same place.

But "unlikely" is not a control. Whether the PCL-AI should carry a per-group hurdle — a minimum within-group score required in addition to the overall standard — is a genuine question on which competent assessment professionals differ. A hurdle protects against exactly the profile above. It also raises the overall difficulty in a way that is hard to justify without evidence, intro-

duces a second decision point with its own measurement error, and can fail candidates who are competent overall on the basis of a small number of items in one group. **Professional judgement**, and labelled as such.

The Institute's position today: **no hurdle is published, and none is applied**. The question will be put to the job-task analysis and the standard-setting study, which are the only instruments that can answer it with evidence rather than argument. If a hurdle is introduced, it will be published as a major version of [EXB-01](#) with an effective date and a notice period, and it will not be applied retrospectively.

— 7. How this goes wrong

Treating the group weight as a difficulty rating. A 20 per cent weight does not mean the AI items are easier, shorter or more forgiving. It means there are fewer of them. Weight and difficulty are unrelated quantities, and candidates routinely conflate them.

Revising by domain count instead of by weight. Thirteen domains invites thirteen equal blocks of study time. That allocation gives Domain 13 about 7.7 per cent of the effort against 20 per cent of the paper, and over-serves Group 2 by a wide margin. The arithmetic in §3.4 is the correction.

Assuming the weighting maps onto the day job. It does not, and it is not meant to. A cost engineer may spend ninety per cent of the week inside Group 2 content. The examination weights what the credential attests, not what a particular role happens to do this year.

Reading a strong overall score as uniform competence. Candidate B in §3.1 passed comfortably with close to nothing in the AI group. That is what a compensatory model permits. Employers reading a PCL-AI result should read the domain breakdown, not only the outcome.

Quoting a per-domain percentage. Some legacy material carries indicative per-domain figures from an earlier grouping of the same thirteen domains. Those figures are superseded and are not the published specification. The current published weighting is the three group weights in §2 and nothing else.

— 8. Checklist

For a candidate planning revision:

- [] I have converted my diagnostic scores into weighted contributions using the formula in §3, not compared raw domain percentages.
- [] I know what my current profile scores overall, and by how much it clears or misses 65 per cent.
- [] I have computed what score I would need elsewhere if I left my weakest group where it is.
- [] My study hours are allocated against the implied per-knowledge-area weights in §3.4, not evenly across thirteen domains.
- [] I have not assumed that a lower group weight means easier items.

For a training provider or reviewer:

- [] Course hours are allocated against the published group weights, and the allocation is stated to learners.

- [] The course teaches the density point in §3.4 explicitly, rather than letting learners infer effort from domain count.
- [] No per-domain percentage is quoted to learners, because none is published.
- [] The compensatory model and its floor problem in §6 are disclosed rather than glossed.

A weighting is the one part of an examination specification that changes candidate behaviour before anyone sits it. Publishing ours with the arithmetic attached means a candidate can check our reasoning, a provider can build against it, and a reviewer can hold us to it when the job-task analysis reports — which is the point at which this weighting stops being a considered judgement and starts being an evidenced one, or gets changed.

— Related

- [EXB-01 – Examination blueprint – PCL-AI](#) — the authoritative statement of the weighting, the syllabus and the format
- [EXB-05 – Standard setting: modified Angoff and the pass mark](#) — how much of the weighted score is enough, and who decides
- [EXB-06 – Job-task analysis: where the blueprint gets its authority](#) — the study that will test this weighting against evidence
- [PCB-03 – Why 40/40/20 – the weighting and what it claims](#) — the same decision read from the body of knowledge rather than the examination

— Sources and standards

The weighting, domain structure and knowledge-area counts are taken from the PCI Body of Knowledge ([docs/bok/](#)) and the published blueprint in [EXB-01](#). All arithmetic in §3 and §6 is illustrative, computed from those published proportions, and independently recomputed before submission.

No external citation is claimed for this document.

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